“Every species in the coastal zone is influenced in one way or another by the ecological effects of sea otters.”

James Estes

American marine biologist

Keystone plants

Not all keystone species are animals. One example is the fig tree, of which there are about 750 species, mostly found in tropical forests. In this habitat, most fleshy-fruited plant species share one or two peaks of ripening each year. Fig trees bear fruit throughout the year, supporting many animals when other trees are fruitless. More than 10 percent of the world’s bird species and 6 percent of mammals (a total of 1,274 species) are known to eat figs, as do a small number of reptiles and even fish. Fig trees therefore provide a vital support mechanism for fruit-eating species. Without them, fruit bats, birds, and other creatures would decline or disappear.

“By protecting a keystone species such as the prairie dog, the public could be educated about the value of ecosystem conservation.”

Brian Miller

American ecologist